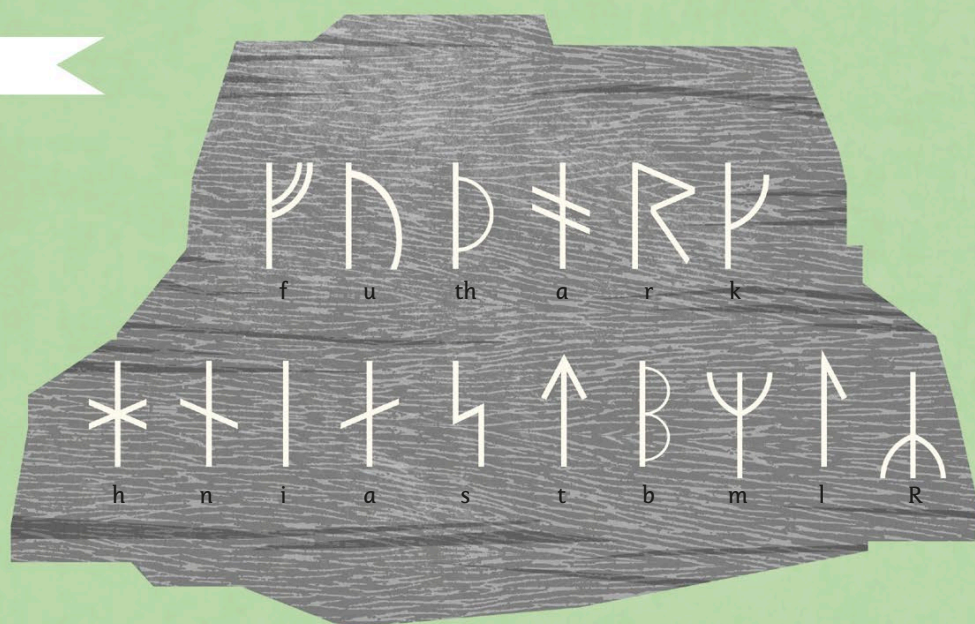


RUNES

Vikings wrote using symbols called runes. The runes were designed with simple lines so they could be carved quickly and easily onto stone or wood. The Norse alphabet was called “futhark”, after the first six letters: f, u, th, a, r and k.



Rune letters

NORSE POETRY

The Vikings loved to sit around the fire listening to poems. Norse poetry can be divided into two types. Eddic poems featured myths and stories starring the gods. Skaldic poems usually retold historical events. They were written by Skalds (poets) for Scandinavian kings and leaders.



Snorri Sturluson (1179-1241) was an Icelandic historian and poet who wrote *The Prose Edda* using older sources. Much of our knowledge of Norse mythology comes from this important literary work.



WRITING THE STORIES

It wasn't until after the Viking Age that the Norse myths were written down. *The Prose Edda* was written in the 1200s and is a mixture of prose and poetry. It includes accounts of the Norse creation myth, the wars between the gods, giants, dwarfs and elves, and the final battle of Ragnarök.